EPIC ACCELERATE 4

EUPHEMISMS

The Polite Language

Ms. Corine Mae Alvia - Rabara

Examples

Service interruption

Examples

Throw under the bus

Recap

Informal Language

prioritizes speed, familiarity, and

emotional honesty

Formal Language

prioritizes clarity, politeness, professionalism, and institutional norms

Euphemisms sit inside formal language, not outside it.

They are a formal strategy, not a casual one.

Are what happens when formal language needs to address uncomfortable realities.

Euphemisms

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So, what are

EUPHEMISMS?

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Euphemisms

A Brief Historical Timeline

Etymology

Origin: Greek ***euphemismos***

eu = well

pheme = speech

To “eupheme” was to speak well of — or use nice words.

Ancient Period (Greek & Roman Era)

Euphemisms were used to avoid offending gods or invoking misfortune; indirect language was believed to offer protection.

Early Modern Period (16th–18th Century)

Politeness and social hierarchy shaped language use; euphemisms became markers of refinement and education.

20th Century

Governments and institutions adopted euphemisms to soften political, military, and bureaucratic realities.

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Theme: Euphemism

Medieval Period

Euphemisms reflected religious values and moral taboos, especially when discussing death, illness, and the human body.

Victorian Era (19th Century)

Strict norms of modesty led to widespread euphemistic language in public and formal discourse.

Contemporary Workplace

professionalism, manage relationships, and reduce the impact of negative information.

Euphemisms are used to maintain

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So, why use

EUPHEMISMS?

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Euphemisms

Socially or politically correct turn of phrase used in place of another term that may be offensive or difficult.

Are used to allude to delicate topics and to avoid censorship.

Euphemisms

Replace words which make people feel unpleasant or disrespected with words which are vague to make people feel pleasant.

- Stocker & Hartman (2000), "Linguistics Dictionary"

Etymology

Euphemism literally means

“to speak with good words”

(Halliday 2001)

OVERWEIGHT

FULL-FIGURED

BIGBONED CHUBBY

PLUMP

VOLUPTUOUS

PORTLY

Fat

WORKING CLASS OF

MODEST MEANS OF

HUMBLE ORIGINS

LOW-INCOME

UNABLE TO MAKE

ENDS MEET

IN DEBT

Poor

Usage

Avoid using words that have a negative stigma attached to them

Avoid offending others by speaking of taboo or sacred subjects directly

Over-inflate the importance of certain

words Obscure meaning from others

Situational Usage

Euphemisms are most commonly used in situations in which a speaker wants to avoid talking directly about certain topics or to mitigate their severity.

Topics

Addressed indirectly through the use of

euphemisms:

death sex

body parts

bodily functions

Avoidance Euphemisms

“Let’s circle back to this…”

Avoidance Euphemisms

“Let’s circle back to this…”

The issue is postponed - possibly indefinitely

Avoidance Euphemisms

“We’ll take this under advisement”

Avoidance Euphemisms

“We’ll take this under advisement”

Saying “No” or “We’re unlikely to approve this.”

Avoidance Euphemisms

“Let’s explore other options.”

Avoidance Euphemisms

“Let’s explore other options.”

Saying “This idea isn’t good enough.”

Mitigating Euphemisms

Used to cause something to become less harsh or hostile OR

Make something less severe, painful, or intense

Topics: economic and social injustices, war crimes, and death.

Mitigating Euphemisms

For Economic & Social Injustices:

“Economically disadvantaged”

“Low-income communities”

Mitigating Euphemisms

“Economically disadvantaged”

softens/hides: Poverty

“Low-income communities”

softens/hides: Systemic poverty

Mitigating Euphemisms

For War Crimes & Political Violence: **“Collateral damage”**

“Enhanced interrogation

techniques”

Mitigating Euphemisms

“Collateral damage”

Avoids saying: Civilian deaths

“Enhanced interrogation techniques”

Avoids saying: Torture

Mitigating Euphemisms

For Death:

“Laid to rest”

“Did not make it”

Mitigating Euphemisms

“Laid to rest”

Direct meaning: Buried

“Did not make it”

Direct meaning:
Died (often in accidents or hospitals)

Informal vs Euphemistic vs Formal

A Comparison

For The Workplace

Situation

Poor performance

Informal:

“You’re bad at this.”

Euphemistic (Formal):

"There's room for improvement."

Clear & Professional:

"Your output does not meet current performance standards."

Situation

Job loss

Informal:

“You’re fired.”

Euphemistic (Formal):

“Your role is being made redundant.”

Clear & Professional:

“Your employment will end on March 15 due to restructuring.”

Situation

Disagreement

Informal:

“That won’t fly.”

Euphemistic (Formal): **“That may be challenging.”**

Clear & Professional: **“This approach presents several feasibility**

issues."

Types of Euphemisms

Types of Euphemisms

Abstraction euphemisms

create new scenarios to refer to

unpleasant or embarrassing situations by abstracting well-known facts

example: “casualties of war” for dead or wounded people.

Types of Euphemisms

Indirection euphemisms

change the focus of unpleasant or

embarrassing situations by using words that direct attention to a different thing example: “sleeping together” for having sexual intercourse.

Types of Euphemisms

Litotes

downplay topics by using understatements

that emphasize the exact opposite of the topic's meaning

example: "not exactly starving" for "very hungry."

Types of Euphemisms

Mispronunciation

alters the sounds in explicit words to keep

language appropriate while still expressing frustration

example: “darn” for “damn” and “cripes” for “Christ.”

Types of Euphemisms

Modification

softens harsh topics by converting a noun

to an adjective

example: “he has foolish beliefs” instead of “he is a fool.”

Types of Euphemisms

Personification

allows uncomfortable topics to be discussed more easily by giving them a

personal name rather than a technical name
example: a visit from Aunt Flo” when referring to menstruation.

Euphemisms in action

Euphemisms used to

inflate or mislead

Secretary

Alternative terms:

administrative assistant,
clerical assistant,
executive assistant,
personal assistant

Janitor

Alternative terms:

custodian
caretaker
superintendent
maintenance worker

Fake

Alternative terms:

genuine imitation leather

OEM

mirror copy

Jail / Prison

Alternative terms:

Correctional facility

Euphemisms in action

Euphemisms obscure meaning from others

Four positives and

four deltas

Giving feedback re: pros and cons / advantages and disadvantages

A Reduction in force

Right-sized

Simplified

Adjusting to shifts in demand

Firing / laying-off people from work

Downsized/ing

Reshaping

Normal payroll adjustment ***Firing /***

laying-off people from work

Strong personality

Positive or negative

impression

Teachable moment

Opportunity for improvement

Negative feedback

Traditional Euphemisms

Are closely related to taboo things such as birth, death, disease, and so on.

Euphemisms for sex: Getting lucky
Making love
Sleeping together

Euphemisms for death: Kick the bucket
Pass/ed on
(to be) In a better place

Stylistic Euphemisms

Euphemisms for ugly:
Plain
Ordinary
Homely

Euphemisms for old:seasoned man

senior citizen

the mature

Euphemisms at work

Business Euphemisms

Grateful words

We highly appreciate your kind cooperation. We are extremely grateful to you.

Vague words

We were very pleased to receive your order NO.23 for TV.

We regret to say that we cannot accept your offer, as your price found on the high side.

Substitution with synonyms

The broken glass was attributed to improper packing.

Substitution with synonyms

More examples

tell = inform

sent = dispatch

wrong packing = improper packing

bad quality = inferior quality

Phrasing

Euphemisms

Grammar

Passive Voice

The police force is being

***streamlined*.**"We are reducing police numbers."

Passive Voice

“No books are allowed to be taken out of the room.”

(agent of actions is removed)

Passive voice

A period of negative growth has been forecast.

"A recession is pending."

Negativism

“Not bad.”

“It’s ok.”

Negativism

"We are very sorry not to be in a position to accept your order, but hope that you will understand our situation."

Past tense

“I thought someone could help me with it”

"Someone come help me."

Past tense

"We are very sorry not to be in a position to accept your order, but hope that you will

understand our situation."

Past tense

“It would not be fair if the loss be totally imposed on us as the liability rests with both parties.“

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So, why do

WORKPLACES

prefer

EUPHEMISMS

?

Ms. Corine Mae Alvia - Rabara

Why Workplaces Prefer Euphemisms

Workplaces use euphemisms to manage tone, relationships, and risk.

Why Workplaces Prefer Euphemisms

They help professionals:

Maintain politeness and respect

Avoid conflict and emotional escalation

Navigate hierarchy and power dynamics

Protect organizational image

Why Workplaces Prefer Euphemisms

Euphemisms allow difficult messages to be delivered without

sounding hostile or unprofessional.

Euphemisms as a Formal Language Strategy

Euphemisms function within formal workplace language, not informal

speech.